

A Comparison of Prithvi Narayan Shah and King Sejong the Great.

Introduction:

Many countries choose important historical figures to appear on their currency because these people represent national pride and identity. Nepal features **Prithvi Narayan Shah**, the king who unified the country and laid the foundation of modern Nepal. Korea features **King Sejong the Great**, one of its most respected rulers, best known for creating the Korean alphabet. Although they lived in different times and cultures, both leaders had a major influence on their nations. This essay compares their backgrounds, achievements, and long-term impact.

Prithvi Narayan Shah: Founder of Modern Nepal.

Prithvi Narayan Shah (1723–1775) was born in the Gorkha Kingdom when Nepal was divided into many small states that often fought with each other. After becoming king, he believed Nepal would be safer and stronger if united. He spent many years planning military campaigns, forming alliances, and leading battles to bring the scattered kingdoms together.

His greatest achievement was the successful unification of the Kathmandu Valley in 1768. This event is seen as the starting point of modern Nepal. Because of this, he is often called the “Father of the Nation.” He also shared important ideas about Nepal’s geography and political situation. His famous statement that Nepal is a “**yam between two boulders**” shows his awareness of Nepal’s position

between India and China and the need to balance relations with both. His ideas about unity, independence, and national strength still influence Nepal today.

King Sejong the Great: A Leader of Knowledge and Innovation.

King Sejong the Great (1397–1450) ruled Korea during the Joseon Dynasty, a period of stability that allowed him to focus on improving society rather than fighting wars. His most important achievement was the creation of **Hangul**, the Korean alphabet. Before Hangul, only highly educated people could read Chinese characters, which meant most ordinary people were illiterate. King Sejong wanted everyone to be able to read and write, so he introduced a simple and scientific alphabet designed for common people. Today, Hangul is considered one of the most efficient writing systems in the world.

Besides Hangul, King Sejong supported many other advancements. He encouraged scientific inventions such as improved clocks, rain gauges, and maps. He also worked to improve farming techniques, government fairness, and public welfare. Because of his dedication to knowledge and innovation, he is remembered as one of Korea's greatest kings.

Similarities Between the Two Leaders.

Although their achievements are different, Prithvi Narayan Shah and King Sejong share important similarities.

First, both strengthened their nations in long-lasting ways—Shah through unification and Sejong through education and science.

Second, both leaders cared deeply about the well-being of their people. Shah wanted a strong and independent Nepal, while Sejong

wanted common people to have access to knowledge. Finally, both leaders are national symbols today, which is why they appear on their countries' currency. Their images represent unity, pride, and important turning points in their histories.

Differences Between the Two Leaders:

There are also clear differences in how they led and what they accomplished.

Prithvi Narayan Shah was mainly a military leader who focused on bringing separate kingdoms together. His leadership depended on strategy, battles, and political alliances.

King Sejong, on the other hand, ruled during a stable period and concentrated on cultural and scientific progress. Instead of uniting territory, he united his people through literacy and knowledge.

Another difference is their legacy: Shah is remembered for creating the modern Nepali state, while Sejong is remembered for giving Korea its unique writing system and promoting education.

Conclusion:

Prithvi Narayan Shah and King Sejong the Great played very different roles in history, yet both shaped their countries in lasting ways. Shah united Nepal and built the foundation of the nation, while Sejong improved life in Korea through the creation of Hangul and support for science and learning. Their presence on national currency reflects the deep respect their countries have for them. Although their methods and achievements were different, both leaders strengthened their nations and left legacies that continue to influence Nepal and Korea today.